

ASHINAGA ASSIGNMENT SUBMISSION

Track Focus: Career Development & Graduate Relations (CDGR)

Status: Final Revised Application Material

SECTION 1: EDITED QUESTION 1 & DESIGN EXPLANATION

THE CATALYST: REWRITING ECONOMIC AGENCY

Spotlight: Local Enterprise & Localized Leadership

From Local Heritage to Global Market: The Story of Bethlehem Tilahun Alemu

In Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, local artisan talent historically remained isolated from sustainable economic networks. Bethlehem Tilahun Alemu recognized that while local craftsmen possessed highly developed skills, they lacked structural entry points into the global market. In 2004, she founded *soleRebels*, an eco-friendly footwear company engineered around local workforce capabilities and recycled raw materials, including traditional hand-spun organic cotton, local hemp, and recycled vehicle tires.

"We wanted to prove that global-standard manufacturing can emerge completely from localized African talent, shifting the paradigm from passive reliance to competitive enterprise."

By adapting indigenous manufacturing techniques—such as the traditional Ethiopian *se/ate* tire shoe—to meet western consumer preferences, *soleRebels* became a rapidly growing global footwear brand, establishing a corporate retail footprint across North America, Europe, and Asia. Bethlehem's operational execution redefines international perspectives on East African trade, demonstrating that long-term social impact is driven by sustainable commercial infrastructure rather than temporary financial aid.

Design & Message Explanation

When creating this newsletter layout, my primary goal was to move past the traditional, often passive depictions of East African communities that frequently dominate international media. Instead of reinforcing narratives of dependency, I chose to highlight Bethlehem Tilahun Alemu's business model to anchor the visual storytelling around genuine local innovation and commercial independence.

To achieve this, I intentionally avoided standard design trends or overly flashy modern web aesthetics. Instead, I leaned toward a clean corporate palette dominated by deep navy and slate-blue. This approach lends immediate professional credibility to the content, which I believe is essential when speaking to corporate recruiters and regional stakeholders. The layout itself features a distinct visual hierarchy: a structured title card serves as an instant anchor, and dedicated text blocks isolate key quotes to make the piece highly skimmable and natural to read.

For me, this story hits close to home when thinking about the core focus of the CDGR division. It addresses the exact friction that Ashinaga Scholars face when returning home: the challenge of bridging a great overseas education with the ground realities of local markets. Bethlehem's success shows that sustainable development isn't born from charity, but from building real infrastructures that respect and scale homegrown talent. I see this narrative

as a practical roadmap for returning scholars. It proves that combining localized cultural insight with clear operational standards allows them to turn complex local challenges into thriving enterprises, shaping a self-reliant future for their communities.

SECTION 2: EDITED QUESTION 2 (OPPORTUNITY ACCESS FRAMEWORK)

To effectively clear the path for returning scholars, we cannot just look at the volume of open jobs; we have to address how difficult it is for an international graduate to actually access them. I would anchor our market engagement strategy around a single, unified **Opportunity Access Framework** built across three layers: Discovery, Validation, and Prioritization.

Layer 1: Discovery (Finding Where Hiring Actually Happens)

I would start by narrowing down where real hiring actually happens, not just where jobs are posted online. Broad job boards waste a lean team's time. Instead, I would narrow our focus to three precise targets, acknowledging the concrete trade-offs each one presents:

- **Pan-African Recruitment Firms (e.g., Talent2Africa):** These platforms are built specifically for returnee pipelines and offer high-volume access across multiple countries. However, the trade-off is variable quality. Many listings are highly transactional or mid-career, meaning we must dig deep to extract entry-level placements suitable for recent grads.
- **Multilateral Institutions & DFIs (e.g., The African Development Bank Graduate Track):** These opportunities carry massive prestige and long-term career impact, giving our scholars an unmatched seat at development policy tables. The trade-off here is volume and speed. It is an incredibly high-impact but low-volume channel, defined by long, rigid hiring windows that do not always line up with university graduation dates.
- **Data-Driven Employment Accelerators (e.g., Harambee Youth Employment Accelerator):** These organizations are excellent for understanding localized skill gaps and tracking direct placements on the ground. The trade-off is geographic scale. While their systems are highly effective in specific regions like South Africa or Rwanda, they lack immediate cross-continent mobility for scholars wanting to return home to other countries.

Layer 2: Validation (Filtering Out Low-Conversion Pipelines)

Once we discover potential partners, the next step is assessing historical data and tracking metrics that protect our scholars from underemployment or logistical dead-ends. I would explicitly measure three reality-checks:

- **Conversion Velocity:** Tracking the true percentage of internships that convert into full-time, permanent contracts with the same employer. If a firm uses interns for cheap seasonal labor without intent to hire long-term, they lose priority.
- **Skills Utilization Match:** Auditing whether our technical and quantitative graduates are actually utilizing their specialized skills or are being misallocated to basic administrative tasks.
- **Cross-Border Friction:** Evaluating how easily a scholar can navigate visa compliance and onboarding structures if they are moving between different regional trading blocs (such as moving from a West African home country to an East African corporate hub).

Layer 3: Prioritization (Balancing Maximum Impact and Lean Resources)

Because our team cannot manage hundreds of corporate accounts simultaneously, we have to make explicit choices about where to spend our energy. I would categorize all corporate relationships into a clear, actionable operational matrix:

Focus Tier	Strategic Reality & Trade-offs	Team Action Plan
Tier 1: High-Conversion Partners	Organizations with active graduate tracks, competitive local pay scales, and a clear record of converting internships to full-time hires. High-yield, but takes intensive relationship management.	I would invest heavily here to establish formal institutional MOUs and create direct channels for candidate matching.
Tier 2: Tactical Openings	Firms with seasonal hiring or specialized technical needs that fit specific scholar majors perfectly. High-volume opportunity, but requires careful individual filtering.	Maintain active communication, invite them to annual panels, and send structured candidate CV books twice a year.
Tier 3: Low-Yield Channels	Unstructured roles, companies with repetitive regulatory visa hurdles, or partners with low historical conversion rates. Unpredictable quality and high administrative drag.	I would step back from active outreach here, tracking them passively or leaving them as self-directed options for scholars.

To make these connections functional, I would move away from passive virtual career fairs. Instead, I would focus on interactive, low-drag interventions: sector-specific spotlights where hiring managers break down actual technical entry tests, alumni roundtables unpacking the real personal and financial adjustments of moving back home, and reverse pitching sessions where our graduating scholars present their final-year projects directly to pre-vetted corporate recruiters.

SECTION 3: CONCLUSION / REFLECTION

Reviewing and refining this application highlights a fundamental truth about working within the Career Development and Graduate Relations (CDGR) division: successful placement is not an administrative numbers game, it is an exercise in strategic matching. It is easy to generate a long list of prestigious employers or draft beautiful marketing material. The real challenge—and where I intend to focus my energy during this internship—lies in managing the complex logistical frictions, regional cross-border steps, and individual candidate realities that separate a job application from a sustainable career path.

By looking at the market through a clear, unified Opportunity Access Framework, we can avoid spreading a lean team too thin over low-conversion channels. This approach allows us to double down on high-velocity corporate networks while actively preparing our scholars for the real commercial, operational, and cultural environments they will step into when they return home. Ultimately, this isn't just about ensuring graduates find employment; it is about building a highly practical, reliable bridge that turns international education into localized economic leadership.